

The Putumayo Atrocities and the Reproduction of Genocide

Introduction

Although most of the latex produced during the period of wild rubber was tapped by workers bound by debt rather than violence, there existed pockets of violence in the rubber industry so brutal that they seem to defy analysis. Contemporary interpreters resorted to metaphor, calling the rubber produced in these regions "red rubber," or "the devil's milk," and naming the part of the Amazon where slavery was practiced "the devil's paradise." The most notorious of these regions was in Africa, which produced about half as much rubber as the Amazon, in the Congo Free State. King Leopold II of Belgium held the Congo Free State as absolute monarch and he exploited the population and resources with a rare brutality. As a result of his exploitation of the native population to produce ivory and rubber "between 1880 and 1920, the population of the Congo was cut 'by at least a half'," or some 10 million people.¹ When Roger Casement travelled to the Congo in 1903 in his role as British consul, he was convinced that "only a humanitarian crusade could abolish the evils of the Leopoldian regime,"² and he became famous for his advocacy against the rubber atrocities.

Although the scope of the rubber atrocities in the Congo were enormous, and their situation important in the history of rubber, my project focuses on a less well known series of rubber atrocities in the western Amazon around the Putumayo River, which were also exposed by Roger Casement. In this relatively remote region of the Amazon, the Peruvian Amazon Company captured and enslaved the indigenous population and established what has been called a

¹Adam Hochschild, *King Leopold's Ghost* (Houghton Mifflin, 1998), 233.

²William Roger Louis, "Roger Casement and the Congo," *The Journal of African History* 5, no. 1 (1964), 120.

"regime of terror." They killed tens of thousands of the region's inhabitants through forced labor, starvation, and massacres, depopulating the region by 90%. I have chosen to highlight this case over the Congo atrocities primarily because it belongs to the same system of wild rubber collection as existed in the Brazilian Amazon, and so its points of difference are instructive as to the underlying dynamics of wild rubber production in the most productive rubber field on earth: the Amazon. The questions raised in this chapter about forced labor for the market and the reproduction of genocide provide a fertile grounds for research into the Congo as well.

The relationship between the Putumayo rubber atrocities and the capitalist world system is not a simple one, and scholars often consider the operations in the Putumayo antithetical to capitalism. Margarita Serje says that in the Putumayo, "credit and debt, usually considered to be one of the engines of capitalism, were here at the core of a system that was not only opposed to the market logic, but also to the possibility of developing a modern local economy."³ On the contrary, I argue that the Putumayo was dominated by the market. On the one hand, the products produced in the Putumayo were commodities - both rubber and enslaved people were 'produced' for the global and regional market. On the other hand, the Putumayo was - in much the same way as the lower Amazon - a consumer of commodities produced in the core. Serje betrays a teleological conception of capitalism by referring to some ideal of a 'modern local economy'. The Putumayo genocide was not a pre-modern aberration in global capitalism, but a core element. And it was not merely modern, but constitutive of modernity.

To make this case, I will look at several aspects of the rubber industry in the Putumayo. I will first briefly examine relationship between the local Peruvian economy and the world market.

³Margarita Serje, "The Peruvian Amazon Co.: Credit and Debt in the Putumayo 'Wild Rubber' Business," *Enterprise & Society* 22, no. 2 (2021), 478.

I will then look at the operations of the primary corporation in the region, the Peruvian Amazon Company, as well as its actions against the indigenous inhabitants of the Putumayo. I should flag here that although I will not dwell on violent description, any discussion of genocide necessarily contains some graphic elements. I will then move on to an analysis of the racial hierarchy of labor in the Peruvian Amazon Company, paying special attention to the importation of Black laborers from Barbados to serve as overseers for the enslaved natives. Lastly I will look at the ways in which the social structure of genocide was reproduced, the necessarily short-term nature of this reproduction, and the way in which the Peruvian Amazon Company contributed to the larger dynamic of capitalist reproduction on a global scale.

Global Integration

In the early twentieth century, the automotive industry, centered in Michigan, USA, massively stimulated the demand for rubber production. As the main raw material that could not be produced within the United States, Henry Ford and his competitors were required to look outside the US to tropical zones more hospitable to rubber trees. As discussed in the previous chapter, until 1913, the Amazon was by far the largest producer of rubber. Most of this came from the Brazilian region of the Amazon, and the industry had a profound transformation on Amazonian communities. As the region was reoriented towards commodity production for the world market, the dissolution of traditional patterns of communal life was accelerated, domestic commodity consumption was increased, and massive cities grew up, built using materials from Europe and North America. In other words, the growth of the rubber stimulated by the automotive industry led to the increased integration of the economy of the Brazilian Amazon into

the world economy. This integration was, however, not limited to the Brazilian Amazon - the Peruvian Amazon was also pulled into international trade, and the local consumption of international goods increased significantly.

The western Amazon was less productive than the Brazilian Amazon for several reasons: it was further from the coast, it had less infrastructural development, and the quality of the rubber was lower. In 1901-1902 approximately 5% of the rubber produced by the Amazon valley passed through Iquitos, the Peruvian port city on the Amazon River - or 1.4 million⁴ kilograms out of 29 million.⁵ Given that Peru currently covers 13% of the Amazon, and claimed an even larger portion a hundred years ago, it is clear that production in the region, while still significant for the global market, was less productive than the eastern Amazon. The Peruvian region's marginal position in the Amazon rubber industry had several important implications for the relations of production that took hold there. The main characteristics of Amazonian production were present: the debt-relation and the increase in commodity consumption. However, these characteristics were warped by the remoteness of the region and the lower productivity: commodity consumption was more limited than in the rest of the Amazon, and more importantly the debt relation was combined with a genocidal violence exercised by the rubber corporations against indigenous workers. The remainder of this section will contextualize the importation of commodities to the Peruvian rubber fields, and the following sections will deal with the genocidal violence that was employed there.

⁴Rupert J. M. Medd and Hélène Guyot, "Eyewitness Accounts during the Putumayo Rubber Boom: Manuel Antonio Mesones Muro—the 'Madman of the Marañón River,' Carlos Oyague y Calderón—the State Engineer, and Roger Casement—'Not of the Real World' Humanitarian," *Journeys* (New York, USA) 20, no. 2 (2019), 64.

⁵P. W. Barker and E. G. Holt, *Rubber Statistics 1900-1937: Production, Absorption, Stocks and Prices*, no. 181, Trade Promotion Series (U. S. Department of Commerce, 1938).

The purchase and consumption by peripheral regions of goods produced in core regions served to extend the valorization of production in industrial centers. This is not a novel phenomenon. Marx writes of the agricultural revolution in Europe that "[t]he expropriation and eviction of a part of the agricultural population not only set free for industrial capital the workers, their means of subsistence and the materials of their labour; it also created the home market."⁶ The means of subsistence that were formerly provided outside the market by the reproductive labor of the family and community have been turned into commodities; they "are now transformed into articles of manufacture, the markets for which are found precisely in the country districts."⁷ Marx is speaking of the division between the town and country side in Europe, but the dynamic holds true on the global scale: the peripheral countries which provided raw materials to the manufacturing companies of the capitalist core, themselves served as markets for the core's finished goods.

During the period of the rubber boom, Peru increased its importation of US-produced goods, especially consumer good such as tinned foodstuffs. Historian Geoff Bertram, in a study of Peruvian imports, classifies the use cases of imported goods in several categories. Consumer goods imports, such as food, clothing, medicine, and other commodities, fluctuated between 30% and 40% of imports between 1891 and 1930. The value of this category rose from about 5,000 soles in the 1890s to consistently over 50,000 in the 1920s.⁸ This was by far the largest absolute growth of any import category during these years. Other categories, such as manufacturing inputs and fuel fell as a proportion of total imports, while agricultural inputs, such as livestock

⁶Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, trans. Ben Fowkes, vol. 1 (Pelican Books, 1976), 910.

⁷Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, 911.

⁸Geoff Bertram, "End-Use Classification of Peruvian Imports, 1891-1972," St Antonys College Oxford, 1977.

feed grew slightly. The biggest proportional growth in imports was capital goods such as agricultural equipment and machinery - from less than 5% to over 15%.

During this period, the United States grew to be by far Peru's greatest trading partner. In the 1890s, the US accounted for barely 10% of imports to Peru and most years that decade received a yet smaller proportion of its exports. By the mid 1910s, the US accounted for over 50% of Peru's trading, both imports and exports.⁹ The US was displacing the United Kingdom, which fell from over a third of imports and half of exports to about 20% of each over the same period. Some of this change was the result of trade disruptions during the first world war, but the trend of declining trade with Britain and increasing trade with the US had been well established prior to the war.

Despite the remoteness of the Peruvian Amazon, the commodities imported from the US made it to the workers in the rubber fields - especially foodstuffs. Lists of goods for sale at company stores around the Putumayo river include things like tinned milk, lard, and meat¹⁰ - all things being produced for export in spades in the US. Centered in Chicago, the US meatpacking industry was highly rationalized - the automation of Chicago slaughterhouses had even provided inspiration for the automotive assembly line. This industry was growing rapidly during the late 19th and early 20th centuries, and in 1909 over 88 million animals were slaughtered for food, mostly hogs and cows but also sheep.¹¹ This massive operation fed the meatpacking business,

⁹Dirección de Estadística del Ministerio de Fomento, *Extracto Estadístico correspondiente al año 1918* (Lima, Peru, 1919), 57.

¹⁰Roger Casement, *Correspondence Respecting the Treatment of British Colonial Subjects and Native Indians Employed in the Collection of Rubber in the Putumayo District : July 1912*, Miscellaneous ; No. 8 (1912) (His Majesty's Stationery Office, 1912), 22.

¹¹US Census Bureau, *Slaughtering and Meatpacking* (1910), 345.

and in 1910 exports were in excess of \$130 million.¹² This canned, salted, pickled, or otherwise cured meat was precisely the type of food that sustained rubber workers in the Putumayo.

The Putumayo Genocide

The food shipped in from the US was generally very expensive, of low quality, and it replaced the more nutritious local diet. Indeed, the effects of integration into the global market were uniformly detrimental to the people who lived in the western Amazon, undermining indigenous communities, and introducing severe forms of exploitation and violence. This is true throughout the Amazon, but was especially severe in the western region. In addition to the debt bondage that prevailed in Brazil, in the western Amazon indigenous peoples were enslaved and forced to work for rubber companies. The best documented case of Amazonian rubber slavery was in the Putumayo region of Peru (now Colombia). There rubber companies enslaved the native inhabitants with methods so brutal that tens of thousands died in a rubber genocide. The system that prevailed in Putumayo was a brutal one, but it should not be thought of as 'pre-capitalist' or 'non-capitalist.' Rather it was an integral part of the global system of capitalist production. The brutality of the rubber companies was a response to the demands of the global market, and the problems of commodity production in such a difficult and remote region determined the living and laboring conditions of the rubber workers. This section will examine these conditions, as well as look at how a rigid racial labor hierarchy was established and maintained with the importation of Black workers from Barbados. Family and gender dynamics played an essential role in the consolidation of power, and they were explicitly manipulated by the white company men to subdue both the native workers and the Barbadian overseers. The

¹²US Census Bureau, *Slaughtering and Meatpacking*, 329.

reproductive scheme they established was essential in producing the cheapest possible labor, combining force, debt, and family obligations to compel the workers.

The Putumayo River is a tributary of the Amazon river which forms the current border between Colombia and Peru. The river basin is the traditional home of several indigenous peoples: the Huitoto were the most numerous, but there were other groups as well, such as the Bora and Muinane people. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the land north of the river was claimed by both Peru and Colombia, each of whom sent 'settlers' into the area to establish land claims and harvest its rubber. Rubber was booming, and there was certainly a fortune to be made in its exploitation, but the rubber of the Putumayo region was of an inferior quality. In addition to the well-known *Hevea* trees, which can be tapped, the region was home to the lower quality *Castilloa Elastica*, which was often cut down in the process of harvesting its natural latex. Evidently harvesting was so severe that a contemporary observer in 1907 noted that Colombian harvesters complained there was very little of this second type left.¹³ The poor quality of the region's rubber required production costs to be kept low in order that the product might be viable on the world market. Both Colombian and Peruvian companies operating in the region relied heavily on the local indigenous population to perform the actual work of harvesting the latex.

The working conditions were brutal, beyond imagining. Throughout the Putumayo basin, indigenous people were enslaved, compelled to labor as rubber tappers, and massacred in great numbers. In what was known at the time as the Putumayo atrocities, but which is now called the Putumayo Genocide, tens of thousands of the indigenous inhabitants of the region were killed. One of the groups targeted, the Muinane people, were reduced from 2000 to just 20 as a result of

¹³W. E. Hardenburg, *The Putumayo: The Devil's Paradise*, ed. C. R. Enock (T. Fisher Unwin, 1912), 94-5.

the massacres. In 1993, their descendants in the Muinane census still numbered less than 150.¹⁴ Exact figures are disputed, but Roger Casement gives a conservative estimate of 30,000 total victims; the Putumayo region was depopulated by 90% during the rubber boom. In addition to outright massacres, thousands were killed by starvation, overwork, or were forcibly removed from their home region.

The major perpetrator of this genocide was a single company, the J. C. Arana and Hermanos Company which was later renamed the Peruvian Amazon Company (PAC) after receiving a significant investment of British capital in 1907. The origins of the company were relayed by W. E. Hardenburg, an adventurer and engineer who traveled to the Putumayo in search of a rubber fortune. He experienced the brutality of the PAC first hand, and was the first to spread awareness of the atrocities in English. According to Hardenburg, the company was helmed by Julio César Arana, who had originally come to Iquitos as a hat salesman. Julio César Arana began to work with small Colombian rubber interests in the late 1890s, and in 1903 started his own rubber company along with his brothers-in-law. He soon bought out his Colombian partners and attempted to push out the remainder of the Colombian competitors. Hardenburg tells us, based on his conversations with the Colombians, and on his later first hand experience, that Arana and his company were ruthless - when dealing with former partners, Arana "[took] advantage of their ignorance and stupidity to rob them scandalously."¹⁵ When cunning was insufficient, Arana "forced José Cabrera, owner of Nueva Granada, to sell out to them at an insignificant price by threats of killing him, by shooting at him from ambush, by forcibly taking away his Indians [sic], and by the other methods for which this company is known."¹⁶

¹⁴Juan Alvaro Echeverri, "The Putumayo Indians and the Rubber Boom," *Irish Journal of Anthropology* 14, no. 2 (2011): 13–18.

¹⁵Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200.

¹⁶Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 200.

There is something significant in Hardenburg using the phrase "taking away *his* Indians" worth returning to, but for now it's enough to note that over time Arana's methods became more and more terrible. While Hardenburg was visiting Colombian rubber estates in the Putumayo he heard stories of Arana's men attacking his white competitors, murdering their workers, enslaving their children and raping their wives. The PAC conducted raids on independent estates to frighten them out of the region and to steal their rubber stores. In some cases they appear to have been accompanied by Peruvian soldiers, evidently there to enforce Peru's claim to the region.

Hardenburg and his traveling companions were captured in one of these raids and held for some days at one of Arana's estates where it became evident that Arana's violence was not aimed only at competitors, but was directed against the local indigenous population as well. Whereas the Colombian rubber harvesters had paid the native workers - underpaid, to be sure, and often in goods rather than direct wages - the agents of the Peruvian Amazon Company compelled local indigenous groups to collect rubber by force. Slavery is the obvious term for this, but what was described by Hardenburg and then corroborated by the testimonies Casement collected later went far beyond a system of forcibly extracting labor from unfree subjects. It was a regime of terror. The indigenous Huitoto were forced to collect rubber and were provided only the barest amount of food. If they failed to collect enough rubber they were punished severely, and not only the men, but the women and children all bore the scars of the lash, which came to be known as the "marca de Arana."¹⁷ When they grew too old or sick to work they were killed and fed to dogs. Beyond this, the company officers kept harems of girls as young as nine whom they raped and killed at will; they used children as target practice, or lit them on fire for amusement.

¹⁷Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 179-80.

In 1910, after Hardenburg's initial account had been published in the British newspaper *Truth*, Roger Casement was appointed by the UK Foreign Office to travel to the Putumayo to investigate several related matters: "whether any British subjects have suffered or are in distress, and if so from what causes, and whether they stand in need of relief," as well as "the methods of rubber collection and the treatment of the employés of the Company."¹⁸ He was accompanied by a separate committee appointed by the Peruvian Amazon Company itself, which was tasked first with reporting "on the possibilities of commercial development of the company's properties" and secondly "to enquire into the present relations between the native employés and the agents of the company."¹⁹ The British subjects whose welfare formed the primary object of Casement's investigation were men and women from Barbados, recruited in 1904-5 and "shipped for Peru at the request of Señor Abel Alarco, at that time a partner of the firm in question," some of whom stayed with the company long after their initial two year contracts had expired.²⁰ Their testimonies provided the greatest part of the evidence submitted by Casement to the Foreign Office.

Casement arrived in Iquitos on August 31st of 1910, and left for the Putumayo along with the commission from the PAC on September 14th. Casement stayed in the Amazon, visiting various stations within the Putumayo, interviewing company employees and observing the operations until December. His two page preliminary report notes that the charges brought by the men from Barbados against the company "were of the most atrocious kind, and added to the accumulating weight of evidence that we had gathered from station to station, and the condition of the Indian population as we had opportunity to observe it in passing, they left no doubt in our

¹⁸Casement, *Correspondence*, 1.

¹⁹Casement, *Correspondence*, 1.

²⁰Casement, *Correspondence*, 7.

minds that the worst charges against the company's agents were true."²¹ In the testimonies, however, the men from Barbados do not figure as mere witnesses to the company's white agents' atrocities against the native population. Rather they testify in part against themselves, revealing a subjectivity in which they are both the recipients and dealers of terror - active, if often reluctant, participants in the construction of a racialized labor hierarchy.

Although the men from Barbados were initially told that they would be contracted as laborers, there were signs that this was false even before they arrived in Peru. When they arrived in Manaus on the way up the Amazon river they were warned "by outsiders that in the countries to which they were going they would not be employed as labourers, but would be armed and used to force the Indians to work for their employers."²² Several of the men protested and asked for the British vice-consul to intervene and release them from their contracts. Their protests were ignored, however, and they "had to be taken on board the river steamer waiting to convey them to the Putumayo under police supervision."²³ Their suspicions were confirmed upon arrival in Putumayo, as the first group to arrive was immediately armed with rifles and ammunition and sent into the jungle on a raid against the indigenous Andokes people. This raid was in part an attempt to secure labor for the collection of rubber, but it served another purpose as well. The Andokes had previously attacked a group of Colombian settlers who had come to enslave them, and had stolen their rifles. The Barbadians were sent out "on what were termed punitive expeditions" to kill or capture the responsible native people and to recover the lost rifles.

This was to become a pattern, in which the hired Barbadians would be placed between the indigenous people of the Putumayo and their white Colombian or Peruvian oppressors. They

²¹Casement, *Correspondence*, 3.

²²Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

²³Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

were given the jobs that were considered too dangerous or unpleasant for the whites. The rubber which was collected by the indigenous workers had to be carried on foot through difficult forest paths obstructed by deep mud, rivers, and fallen trees. The journey from the furthest rubber station to the river was 70 miles, and took four or five days to traverse. Casement notes that "The Indians were not supplied with food for this journey. They were guarded by armed men both going and returning, and Barbados men frequently were employed for this work, just as they were used, in the first instance, in forcing the Indians to collect the rubber in the forest and bring it into Matanzas."²⁴ This was the general pattern that the Barbadians' labor took: they were engaged both in capturing and disciplining native labor. They held the guns that separated indigenous families and forced them to work past the point of starvation. By the time Casement arrived, only 20 of more than 100 Barbadians remained in the company's employ, but "with the exception of three men at La Chorrera itself, whose duties were those of ordinary labour, all the men ... were employed in guarding or coercing, or in actively maltreating, Indians to force them to work and bring in india-rubber to the various sections."²⁵

Although the men from Barbados were brought in as slave-drivers, but they were also themselves driven. In addition to outlining the debt they incurred and the conditions of starvation they faced, Casement recounts at length four cases in which the Barbadians were tortured and mistreated by the white company agents. Every station that the company owned had a set of stocks that had been built to punish the native workers who drew the ire of company agents. Although the stocks were much too small for the men from Barbados, they were often used as punishment for them too. In at least one case, a Barbadian man named Edward Crichlow was

²⁴Casement, *Correspondence*, 11-12.

²⁵Casement, *Correspondence*, 12.

chained up in the stocks that he himself had built. In other instances, the Barbados men were lifted off the ground and suspended by their arms which had been tied behind their backs - in this posture they were beaten with tapir-hide whips or with machetes. In most cases these punishments were meted out after a minor quarrel with a white employee. It should be noted that the punishments given to the Barbadians, while extreme, were moderate versions of those given to the native population. Where the Barbadians would be held in stocks for a few hours to a few days, a native man would be held for weeks. Where the Barbadians were suspended and beaten, a native man would be hanged until dead.

The relationship between the Barbadians and the indigenous people enslaved by the company in a sense mirrors the racial stratification in Michigan and the rest of the Amazon. Although the stratification was enforced much more violently in the Putumayo, in every region there has been a racialized underclass managed or overseen by a separate racial group(s). Previous chapters have demonstrated that in the factories of Michigan, only a portion of the workforce was paid well enough to consume commodities on an enlarged scale: the workforce was stratified along racial lines into well-paid white wage-workers and under-paid Black and immigrant wage-workers. The poorer workers still consumed commodities, but to a lesser extent, and their consumption was supplemented by informal and reproductive labor, such as family gardens. In Putumayo a stratification was enforced, but between under-paid Black wage-workers and enslaved natives. This stratification manifested through the differential application of violence, but also through differential access to family, food, and other necessities.

Like the white company men, although to a lesser extent, the Barbadian men also took part in the spoils of slavery. Casement reports that "every so-called civilised employé receives

from the agent of the company, on arrival, and Indian woman to be his temporary wife."²⁶

According to Casement, "[w]ith the Barbados men it was no doubt a more or less voluntary contract on each side," but I hesitate to speak of volition in this context. Regardless of their wishes, the women were considered "the direct gift or loan" of the company, and when a worker was reassigned to a different station, there was no guarantee that they would be able to bring their wife or children with them. One Barbadian, Joshua Dyll, evidently had 9 successive "wives" - a new woman was given to him every time he changed post.

The company's interest in this system is clear. Casement notes that "[m]ost of the twenty men I actually encountered in the services of the company were in debt; that is to say, owing to their purchases from the company's stores of things they needed from time to time, either for their own wants or those of their Indian wives and possibly children, they had been debited with amounts which often considerably exceeded the wages credited to them."²⁷ Although the contract between the Barbadians and the company stipulated that in addition to salary, the workers would receive free medicine and food, in reality the men were forced to purchase these at inflated cost from the company stores. Furthermore, once the men were given wives they became responsible also for purchasing their food and medicine, with one official claiming that "their indebtedness in these accounts was 'for medicines required for the men's Indian wives.'"²⁸ These nominal familial ties served to put the workers in the company's debt, which both disallowed the Barbados men from leaving, and cheapened their labor, as the profits from the company store far outweighed their salaries.

²⁶Casement, *Correspondence*, 16.

²⁷Casement, *Correspondence*, 16.

²⁸Casement, *Correspondence*, 19.

Thus the large majority of the salaries of the Barbadians were eaten up by debts - especially for food. Although there was some crop cultivation at the stations, it seems to have not been very extensive. Despite the long odes to the fertility of the Amazon found in the accounts of Hardenburg and Enock, much of the land around the stations was cleared and then left empty. Casement claimed that at one station with 200 cleared acres, "scarcely 1 acre is under any form of cultivation."²⁹ As a result, "[f]ood which might easily be raised locally is brought literally from thousands of miles away at great expense, and often in insufficient quantity."³⁰ Although the terms of the contract stipulated that food would be provided to the Barbadians, in reality they often had to purchase this expensive food from the company, contributing to their great debt. Casement lists the account of Edward Crichlow, which included cassava meal, rice, biscuits, flour, condensed milk, cocoa and milk, preserved meat, sardines, salmon, lard, sugar, tea, and cod roes. All of these except the cassava, the rice, the flour and the tea were in tins. In addition to these foodstuffs were pots, pans, tobacco, soap, and other small items, along with a large quantity of cotton goods.³¹

Casement seemed baffled by the substitution of imported goods for locally grown food, and it is on some level baffling. The immediate decision to undermine local agriculture and rely on tinned food was certainly not made in the name of profit or efficiency. However, there are several possible explanations. Destroying the ability of the native workers to cultivate their own food put them more thoroughly at the mercy of the company. Starvation was a major element of the terror imposed on the Putumayans, and was crucial in the destruction of native communities. Once captured, native women and children seemed to be more prized as sexual objects - both for

²⁹Casement, *Correspondence*, 18.

³⁰Casement, *Correspondence*, 18.

³¹Casement, *Correspondence*, 22.

the enjoyment of company men and as debt-anchors for the Barbadian workers - than as agricultural workers. As for the Barbadians, reliance on food purchased from the station stores was a way for the company to claw back their wages and then some.

Food was also a central point of contention between the Barbadians and the indigenous workers. When the food provided or sold by the company was insufficient, employees "were often forced to steal food from the Indians, or to go out into the forest and the surrounding plantations and look for it and rob it."³² In some cases they had to forage their own food and survive on "a wild herb called by the Indians 'airambo'."³³ On the long marches through the jungle, "[n]o food is to be obtained ... except from the few Indians who may be dwelling in the neighborhood, and these poor people now have little enough for themselves."³⁴ Casement recounts the story of one Barbadian at a station with scarce food supplies. He applied to be transferred and "was glad to be sent to a sub-station where more food was obtainable, chiefly from the Indians, and where his duties mainly consisted in flogging these same Indians."

As enslaved people, the native Putumayans were almost entirely left out of the wage-relation and thus excluded from purchasing commodities. Their communities and existing agricultural practices had been destroyed and so they were often entirely at the mercy of their enslavers for sustenance. Although there was sometimes a nominal system of barter whereby natives traded some rubber for sundry goods from the colonists, this served only to establish a debt against the natives. This debt could never be paid off, and was merely a veneer which covered the system of violent coercion. The economic compulsion of the wage was replaced by the direct compulsion of the whip and so labor was cheapened, but at the cost of removing from

³²Casement, *Correspondence*, 12.

³³Casement, *Correspondence*, 20.

³⁴Casement, *Correspondence*, 11-12.

capital's ambit a potential market. Further, the genocidal viciousness of the slave drivers undermined both the short term and long term reproduction of labor, meaning that labor renewal was largely effected by constant slaving raids.

The system of slavery on the Putumayo destroyed the generational reproduction of native labor, and pushed the daily reproduction to a minimum. Families were separated, with men forced to collect rubber and women and children being taken by company men, enslaved and raped. For the working men, Hardenburg states that their food was "given to them once a day, at noon; it consisted of a handful of *fariña* and a tin of sardines - when there were any - for each group of four Indians, nothing more. And this was to sustain them for twenty-four hours, sixteen of which were spent at the hardest kind of labour."³⁵ On the long marches through the forest, the workers were given no food at all. When the workers inevitably fell ill, they were not given medicine, but were "exposed to the burning rays of the vertical sun and the cold rains and heavy dews of early morning until death released them from their sufferings. Then their companions carried their cold corpses ... to the river."³⁶ The renewal of the labor force depended entirely on a steady stream of newly enslaved workers from a population that was, like the rubber trees, fast dwindling.

Although the native Putumayans were not allowed to labor to meet their own needs, they were compelled to do reproductive labor for the company. In addition to collecting rubber, both men and women were forced to work to provide food and shelter for their enslavers. Casement notes that "[w]hether it was food-stuffs that were required, labour for building houses or planting cassava, sugar-cane, maize, or other produce for the needs of each station, or the collection of

³⁵Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 180.

³⁶Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 180.

india-rubber, the Indians had to satisfy all the demands of the so-called commercial establishment which had planted itself in their midsts."³⁷ Indeed all of the houses at the rubber stations were built by the natives:

The white settlers in the forest from the first compelled the Indians to build houses for them. The plan of the house would be the work of the white man, but the labour involved and all the materials would be supplied by the neighbouring Indian tribe or tribes he had reduced to work for him. All the houses that I visited outside the chief station of La Chorrera in which the company's agents lived, and where their goods were stored, were and are so constructed by the surrounding Indians, acting under the direct supervision of the agent and his white or half-caste employés. This labour of the Indians goes unremunerated. Not only do they build the houses and the stores for the white men, but they have to keep them in repair and supply labour for this purpose whenever called upon.³⁸

These houses were built on huge clearings of up to 200 acres, the clearing and planting of which also fell to the Putumayans.

Reproduction of Genocide

What was the purpose of this system of brutality? Contemporary accounts are shot through with attempts to make sense of something so offensive to sense and reason. It seems to go directly against the considerations operating in both Michigan factories and the rubber fields of the lower Amazon: maintaining an active and renewable labor pool, and stimulating the

³⁷Casement, *Correspondence*, 9.

³⁸Casement, *Correspondence*, 17.

consumption of commodities as well as their production. Genocide is an eradication of a people, not their reproduction, and the native people enslaved by the company were not significant consumers of food commodities, as they were barely given enough food to survive. My framework, however, emphasizes not only the reproduction of people or workers, but the reproduction of the relations of production. From this perspective, the genocide contributed not only to short term profitability, but to the transfer of property from indigenous communities to profit-seeking enterprises, the maintenance of a racially stratified labor force, and even some small amount of commodity circulation by the Barbadian wage workers - although this commodity consumption was still much smaller in extent than in the Brazilian Amazon.

As a social system, the Putumayo genocide was relatively short lived. It might seem odd to speak of the reproduction of a system that cannibalized itself in just a few short years, but the concept of social reproduction includes not only the generational, but also the daily scale. In the Putumayo, the long-term stable reproduction of the system of rubber collection in was sacrificed in order to intensify the short term collection of rubber. This is true both of the consumption of the rubber commodity and the consumption of labor. But in other ways, the Putumayo genocide contributed to the long-term reproduction of the capitalist world-economy itself. This is clear in the way that the destruction of local food production opened up the Putumayo as a market for non-perishable goods, especially tinned meats from abroad. There are several key aspects of social reproduction to be examined here: the establishment and reproduction of property relations, and the perpetuation of the conditions of commodity production.

Land

Industrial production requires raw material inputs, and as production expands to serve the end of capitalist accumulation, the pool of available resources must expand also. This is partly a matter of finding the resources and developing the necessary infrastructure to exploit them, but it is also a matter of social construction. In order to make profit, capital must exploit natural resources as cheaply as possible: as Jason Moore writes, "[t]he condition of the rise of capitalism, in other words, was the creation of Cheap Nature."³⁹ In the case of the Putumayo the natural world had to be made cheap, and capital employed several techniques to do so, such as violent dispossession of the native population and fraudulent accounting practices.

The first person to expose the Putumayo genocide to the English speaking world, Walter E. Hardenburg, also wrote at length about natural wealth of the Putumayo region. Hardenburg was an engineer who traveled to the Putumayo to look for business opportunities, and when he published his travel accounts in book form, they were accompanied by an introduction written by a friend and fellow engineer C. Reginald Enock. Their writings express outrage at the genocide of the indigenous Putumayans, but alongside this is a certain instrumental view of nature. In their view, the Amazon basin itself was an untamed and untapped source of wealth which only needed to be subject to the rationalizing discipline of capital. As they described the natural space of the Putumayo basin and its inhabitants, they did so as surveyors and engineers, cataloging every natural and human element in terms of their potential to produce profit. Enock writes: "In the

³⁹Jason W. Moore, "The Rise of Cheap Nature," in *Anthropocene or Capitalocene? Nature, History, and the Crisis of Capitalism* (PM Press, 2016), 99.

Peruvian Montaña, in its upper regions, Nature has been lavish of her products and opportunities. The rancher who should take up his abode there, with a small amount of capital, can rapidly acquire estates and wealth.... It is sufficient to cut down and burn the brush and scratch the soil and sow any seed, to recover return of a hundred for one."⁴⁰ And a page later: "The whole Amazon Valley, when it shall have been opened up, will prove to be one of the most valuable parts of the earth's surface."⁴¹ What's odd about these quotes is that they are sandwiched between the diatribes against the "savages" of North and South America and the extended musings on the racial mixing of Spanish and Latin American races. It's written in a scattered way, as if Enock couldn't decide between the relative importance of accumulation and expounding his racial theories.

Hardenburg's account is somewhat more focused on profit, as his journey was planned explicitly as an expedition to find potential areas of investment. He wanted to take advantage of the rubber boom, but kept a keen eye on any potentially profitable ventures. He similarly discussed the suitability of the region for agriculture, noting that "[a] part of the valley is low and swampy, but the rest is good, rich soil, quite suitable for agricultural purposes, and covered with a thick, short grass. Although all the encircling mountains are clad with forests, the valley is, at present, cleared and ready for cultivation."⁴² As he traveled down the river, he took samples of rocks that might indicate the presence of valuable minerals.

It was rubber, of course, which stood out as the most profitable venture in the Putumayo. However, the latex producing trees were in general much more difficult to manage than those in the lower Amazon. As mentioned in the previous chapter, there are several species of latex

⁴⁰Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 36.

⁴¹Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 37.

⁴²Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 55.

producing plants:⁴³ *Guayule* which can grow in the US and which produces hypoallergenic rubber;⁴⁴ *Landolphia Owariensis*, an "fragile and easily killed" African vine which served as the principle source of rubber collected during the Congo Genocide;⁴⁵ *Cryptostegia*, which was native to Madagascar but was prohibitively labor intensive to tap;⁴⁶ and literally hundreds more, including the common dandelion. Among the world's latex producing plants *Hevea Brasiliensis* is by far the most productive and most widely processed, but even in its native Amazon it competed with the *Castilla* plant. In fact, *Castilla* processing predated *Hevea* among indigenous peoples, and was initially much more common with several unique advantages. The most important of these was that *Castilla* trees have a much higher short term production, as the "free flow of latex from the tapping cuts ... gave more rubber with less labor than was possible with *Hevea*."⁴⁷ Unfortunately, "they will not produce such yields if tapped more frequently than once or twice per year,"⁴⁸ and in South America it was harvested "by felling and circling the trunks,"⁴⁹ destroying the trees.

In general in 19th century, *Hevea* latex was more common in the eastern Amazon, and *Castilla* in the west. However because the harvesting of *Castilla* latex often destroyed the tree, it began to die out in the wild by the end of the nineteenth century. When Hardenburg traveled through Colombia and Peru in 1907 and 1908 he was told that "the whole region of the Upper Putumayo had once abounded in *caucho negro*," the local name for the rubber produced by

⁴³For a much more extensive list and analysis of the many latex producing plants, see Harold Brown, *Rubber: Its Sources, Cultivation and Preparation* (J. Murray, 1914).

⁴⁴Katrina Cornish et al., "Guayule Latex Provides a Solution for the Critical Demands of the Non-Allergenic Medical Products Market," *Agro Food Industry Hi Tech* 12, no. 6 (2001): 27–32.

⁴⁵Robert Harms, "The End of Red Rubber: A Reassessment," *The Journal of African History* 16, no. 1 (1975): 75.

⁴⁶SR Hoover et al., "Cryptostegia Leaf Rubber," *Industrial & Engineering Chemistry* 37, no. 9 (1945): 803–9.

⁴⁷EM Blair and TF Ford, "Castilla as a Western Hemisphere Rubber," *Industrial & Engineering Chemistry* 37, no. 8 (1945): 760.

⁴⁸Ernest P. Imle, "Hevea Rubber: Past and Future," *Economic Botany* 32, no. 3 (1978): 264–77, JSTOR.

⁴⁹O. F. Cook, "Rubber Production from Castilla and Hevea," *Science* 85, no. 2208 (1937), 406.

Castilla tree, "but that at the present date very little remained, owing to the fierce onslaughts of the *caucheros* many years ago."⁵⁰ Thus there had been a shift to *Hevea*, but there are several ways in which *Hevea* production in the Putumayo region was inferior to that in the lower Amazon.

In the first place, there are several species in the genus *Hevea*, not all of which are as productive as the *Hevea Brasiliensis* which grows in the east. The species that grow in the Putumayo are *Hevea guianensis* and *Hevea benthamiana*, which are the "most productive and highest quality varieties within the category of weak rubber," but which in the rest of the Amazon are less exploited than *Hevea Brasiliensis* "due to their low production and the occasionally sticky character of their latex which makes their rubber undesirable on the market."⁵¹ From July 1901 to June 1902, 1.4 million kilograms of rubber passed through Iquitos, of which only a third was classified as high quality,⁵² compared to about half in Brazil.⁵³ During the final period of Amazonian dominance on the world rubber market, roughly 1900 to 1914, fine rubber averaged a 36% premium over lower quality rubber, peaking at more than double the value in 1910.⁵⁴

The increased difficulty of harvesting rubber in the Putumayo vis-a-vis the rest of the Amazon appears to have been a compounding factor. In describing the harvesting patterns of

⁵⁰Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 95.

⁵¹"La **Hevea guianensis** y su variedad **lutea** y la **Hevea benthamiana** son las tres especies y variedades más productivas y de mejor calidad entre las denominadas siringas fracas o jebes débiles, es decir, gomas de Hevea que tienden a perder mas peso que las siringas verdaderas y que, por lo tanto, tienen menor valor en el mercado. Además, son de extracción más difícil. Con las demás especies y variedades de jebes débiles sólo se realiza su explotación en casos excepcionales, debido a su producción muy baja y, en algunos casos, a las características pegajosas del látex que hace la goma indeseable en el mercado (siringaranas)." Camilo Domínguez and Augusto Gómez, *La Economía Extractiva En La Amazonia Colombiana: 1850 - 1930* (Tropenbos Colombia, 1990), 93.

⁵²Rupert J. M. Medd and Hélène Guyot, "Eyewitness Accounts during the Putumayo Rubber Boom: Manuel Antonio Mesones Muro—the 'Madman of the Marañon River,' Carlos Oyague y Calderón—the State Engineer, and Roger Casement—'Not of the Real World' Humanitarian," *Journeys* (New York, USA) 20, no. 2 (2019), 64.

⁵³Randolph R. Resor, "Rubber in Brazil: Dominance and Collapse, 1876-1945," *The Business History Review* 51, no. 3 (1977), 353

⁵⁴P. W. Barker and E. G. Holt, *Rubber Statistics 1900-1937: Production, Absorption, Stocks and Prices*, no. 181, Trade Promotion Series (U. S. Department of Commerce, 1938), 43.

tappers in Bolivia, contemporary descriptions describe tappers operating one or two looping trails that stayed close to the vicinity of their domicile. The work was organized so as "to make the *estradas* [paths] each of a convenient length for one man to tap all the trees included in it, and carry the rubber milk back to the hut and cure it, in one day."⁵⁵ Tappers would alternate between trails on subsequent days and carry their rubber to their *aviadores* at the end of the week or month. This description differs sharply from that of the Putumayo gathering expeditions, in which enslaved workers would be forced to carry at gunpoint the rubber they had gathered over months sometimes up to 70 miles over hard terrain.⁵⁶ This is indicative not only of the hard conditions of labor, but also of the more dispersed nature of rubber and the lack of infrastructure in the Putumayo which made tapping more labor intensive.

All of this indicates that if the Putumayo was going to compete with the rest of the Amazon, it would not be in the realm of quality. The Putumayo could produce rubber, but given its lower quality and consequently its lower price, to be profitable it would have to drive down the costs of production. This is evident in the methods of labor discipline employed by the PAC: the forced labor, the sub-starvation-level provisions, and the debt relation all served to depress the cost of labor and therefore the cost of producing rubber.

Recent scholarship into the corporate structure and accounting practices of the PAC has deepened our understanding of the methods used to conduct profitable business in the unique economic considerations that differentiated the region from the rest of the Amazon. Although the debt-bondage relation that characterized Amazonian wild rubber production was operative in the Putumayo, it served a somewhat different purpose. Whereas in the lower Amazon, the debt

⁵⁵"The Rubber Situation in Bolivia," *India Rubber World* (New York) 27, no. 1 (1902), 15.

⁵⁶Casement, *Correspondence*, 11-12.

relation allowed workers some level of autonomy, as has been argued convincingly by Barbara Weinstein, in the Putumayo it served to mask the extreme levels of unfreedom that actually prevailed. This was especially important for Arana's solicitation of capital investment in Britain, as the debt relation served to add a veneer of legality to a system of enslavement that otherwise would have deterred British capital investment. As the Putumayo region was contested territory between Colombia and Peru, land deeds were scarce, and the PAC was required to establish the legitimacy of its claim to the land it was exploiting. The debt relation and control over the indigenous population served as a crucial element in their assertion of land rights.

Stephen Walker's recent article "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective" makes the case that the debt-bondage relation is one of many accounting practices which should be "no longer perceived as a purely technical endeavor that is isolated from the organizational and social context in which it is practiced. Accounting information is now comprehended as socially constructed, as value laden, and the production of accounts is recognized as a highly political process."⁵⁷ There were several anomalies in the PAC's accounting practices which contributed both to the extension of control over the native population, and to disguising the violent nature of this control. Among these anomalies were the valuation of land not based on ownership rights but on access to the land's inhabitants, capital outlays for *Gastos de Conquistacion* (expenses of conquest), and the charging of arbitrary debts to the Indigenous workers and treating these debts as company assets.

As Hardenburg had witnessed firsthand, the PAC came into possession of many of its estates through the "systematic persecution of ... Colombian establishments ... with the object of

⁵⁷Stephen P. Walker, "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective," *Enterprise & Society* 25, no. 1 (2024), 282.

making them abandon the region and then taking possession of their properties."⁵⁸ Casement confirms this point, but notes that the Colombians had also been settlers who exploited the native population, and he frequently mentions them as parties to raids and massacres of the indigenous people. The Colombians' purpose in dealing with any Indigenous community was the same as the PAC: "enslaving that tribe and forcing it to work rubber for them."⁵⁹ Although "[i]n some cases these Colombian settlers appear to have held concessions from their government," in the contested region of the Putumayo the legality of land titles was shaky. At any rate by the time the estates passed into the hands of the Peruvians, the majority of their estates did not have legal titles, and "[t]he PAC's chairman conceded that the company held only squatter's rights."⁶⁰ The PAC's rights to the estates had been asserted by extra-legal means and persisted through the overwhelming use of force against anyone who might challenge them - native or Colombian. Far more important than a legal claim to title over the Putumayo was the ability to effectively exploit the land's inhabitants. Whereas land assets are often tallied on a per-acre basis, "PAC accounting practices suggested that valuation was primarily understood to be a function of the presence of exploitable labor."⁶¹ In a rainforest spanning half a continent that was full of rubber, it was primarily the presence of ready workers that would not have to be imported that made the Putumayo unique.

Workers would not have to be imported, but the native Putumayans did not accept enslavement quietly. In fact, their resistance cost the company significantly. In order to subdue the indigenous population, the PAC brought in Black Barbadian migrants to serve as overseers, and laid out significant capital on *gastos de conquistacion*. These armaments, though not

⁵⁸Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 201.

⁵⁹Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

⁶⁰Walker, "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective," 289.

⁶¹Walker, "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective," 292.

representing a large portion of the company's assets, were significant enough to appear on a 1909 financial audit of the PAC, where they were lumped into a category of "office furniture, armaments, and moveable plant."⁶² The head of the PAC, J.C. Arana, argued that "conquest referred to attracting Indians, a process of converting uncivilized people to a relationship of exchange," but a later investigative committee "affirmed that the *Gastos de Conquistacion* represented the cost of the manhunts and slave raids, which 'were regarded as preliminary expenses' of starting a section for collecting rubber."⁶³

The appearance of a large amount of munitions on a list of company assets offers us a glimpse into the violence that underpinned the operations of the PAC. It is a sort of economic residue of non-economic compulsion, and it demonstrates a tension at the heart of the wild rubber industry. In order to cheaply extract rubber from the Putumayo region, the company employed genocidal violence against the local population. But in order to participate in the global economy, all assets had to be accounted for and framed as legitimate - and so the guns were lumped in with office furniture. The contradiction between the violence of the gun and the quieter compulsion of the balance sheet is a fundamental dynamic of global capitalism that plays out in the subjugation of peripheral regions and the transformation of people into workers.

Labor Discipline

Labor scarcity was reported to be an additional pressure on rubber production in the Putumayo, but early diagnoses of labor scarcity in the Putumayo are contested. A contemporary newspaper article mentions that as "labour and women are both scarce, and as there is a strong

⁶²Walker, "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective," 295.

⁶³Walker, "The Peruvian Amazon Company: An Accounting Perspective," 294.

demand for one and the other, bands of armed men are constantly organised for sudden descents upon groups or communities of the savages,"⁶⁴ but more recent analysis indicates that, at least relative to the lower Amazon, the Putumayo had a "a strategic advantage constituted by the large Indian population that had not been decimated by the advances of slave traffickers and Luso-Brazilian settlers of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries."⁶⁵ Insofar as labor was imported, it was not employed in rubber gathering, but in overseeing and disciplining enslaved laborers. Indeed the brutality of the Putumayo Genocide cannot be entirely explained either as a response to difficult conditions of production or the scarcity of labor.

Casement makes the argument in his report that the PAC terrorized and enslaved the Huitoto people as a method of extracting their labor: "The object of the "civilised" intruders, in the first instance, was not to annihilate the Indians, but to "conquistar," i.e., to subjugate them, and put them to what was termed civilised, or at any rate profitable, occupation to their subduers."⁶⁶ The Barbadians were brought in to offset some of the dangers and difficulties of the slaving raids, and overseeing the native workers on their long marches through the forest. Due to the expense of transporting the rubber from the Putumayo to market, the PAC combined debt peonage with extreme violence to maintain a docile and compliant labor force. However, there are several issues with a purely economic explanation. As Michael Taussig claims, torture-as-labor-discipline, while not incorrect, can only be a partial explanation, as "terror and torture do not derive only from market pressure (which we can regard here as a trigger) but also from the process of cultural construction of evil as well."⁶⁷ Indeed, the violence employed by the PAC was

⁶⁴Article from *El Comercio*, 1906 as cited in Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 24.

⁶⁵Serje, "The Peruvian Amazon Co.: Credit and Debt in the Putumayo 'Wild Rubber' Business," 483.

⁶⁶Casement, *Correspondence*, 10.

⁶⁷Michael Taussig, "Culture of Terror--Space of Death. Roger Casement's Putumayo Report and the Explanation of Torture," *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 26, no. 3 (1984), 479.

not only directed at the native workers, but at their entire communities and even the salaried Barbadian employees. More significantly, the brutality of the PAC undermined the workforce by starving, maiming, and ultimately slaughtering thousands of would-be rubber tappers.

Given the apparent insensibility of the genocide from an economic standpoint, it is easy to see why scholars have considered it a pre-capitalist relic. Seen within the proper context, however, it is clear that the brutality of the PAC was an element of the ongoing process of racial stratification that is a constituent component of the capitalist world. The horror of the Putumayo genocide can here be placed within the much longer project of what Michael Taussig calls the "construction of colonial reality that occurred in the New World... where the Indian and the African became subject to an initially far smaller number of Christians."⁶⁸ The brutality of the PAC's methods were crucial in the elaboration, not only of a new kind of man, but of new kinds of family and a new kind of society built on a rigid racial hierarchy. Terror played a fundamental role in this elaboration: terror "which as well as being a physiological state is also a social fact and a cultural construction whose baroque dimensions allow it to serve as the mediator *par excellence* of colonial hegemony."⁶⁹

The actions of the Peruvian Amazon Company can be seen as a continuation of colonial policy against indigenous peoples in the Americas. The discussion of how to frame their actions is in a sense a continuation of the Valladolid debate: an attempt by European conquering powers to, as Jason Moore says "justify and enable the profit-driven conquest, appropriation, and exploitation of humans and the rest of nature so as to sustain the endless accumulation of capital."⁷⁰ Part of the justification came from framing resistance by the indigenous Putumayans

⁶⁸Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468.

⁶⁹Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 468.

⁷⁰Jason W. Moore, "Our Capitalogenic World: Climate Crises, Class Politics, and the Civilizing Project," *Annales Universitatis Paedagogicae Cracoviensis. Studia Poetica* 11 (2023), 98.

as evidence of their brutality and backwardness: Taussig notes that propaganda of the "savagery of the wild Indians occupied a key role in the propaganda of the rubber company."⁷¹ The genocide was indeed a Civilising Project by a "civilising company" in that it was an attempt to impose a civilizational order that not only extracted cheap labor from its racialized subjects, but that actively devalued both indigenous populations and their ways of life, as well as the natural world.

In his introductory remarks to the republication of Peruvian Judge Valcarcel's *El Proceso del Putumayo*, Alberto Chirif outlines a long lineage of resistance by Indigenous Amazonians to European colonization. He identifies three successive periods in which different justifications were claimed for the domination of the indigenous Americans.⁷² Initially, the indigenous peoples were subjugated and enslaved by Europeans on the grounds that they were no human, but after the papal bull of 1537 which declared their humanity, the justification shifted. The natives peoples of the Americas were now considered human but atheists, and the west was justified in taking responsibility for their salvation. Finally, with the development of secularism in the 19th century, the theory of evolution was taken up by the advocates of western civilization who framed indigenous peoples as savage enemies of civilization. However, as Chirif notes, each of these successive justifications for conquest were in reality cumulative - they built on each other to further the civilizing project.⁷³ In the development of this logic, any action that the indigenous peoples took was framed negatively. If they fought back they were considered as either subhuman or heathen savages, and if they didn't then they had "weakness of character and

⁷¹Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 484.

⁷²Carlos A. Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos* (CETA, 2004), 28.

⁷³Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 28: "Las tres imágenes históricas elaboradas por los occidentales para justificar su dominio frente a los indígenas (no-humanos, ateos y salvajes), en realidad no son sucesivas sino acumulativas."

docility of temperament." Moments of resistance especially were incorporated into the civilizing narrative as justifying the brutal methods of subjugation.

In the case of Peru, the state was interested in incorporating the resource-rich Amazon into the national economy, as it was being under-utilized by its inhabitants.⁷⁴ In the 1860s, Peru began to assert its presence in the rain forest, and in 1866 sent a steamship along the Putumayo to determine its navigability. In August the steamship was attacked by the region's inhabitants, and two men were killed. In response, a second team was sent out with the express purpose of demonstrating the superiority of the Peruvians. This demonstration took the form of a massacre: an unrecorded number of dead men, along with three women and fourteen children taken prisoner. The place was renamed by the Peruvians the "port of Punishment."⁷⁵

This pattern of indigenous resistance to Peruvian incursion being met with overwhelming violence was continued in the Putumayo. As noted previously, the first task of the Barbadians after they arrived in the Putumayo was to conduct a series of retaliatory raids on the Andokes people. These raids were characterized in two ways - on the one hand they were intended to "open up what were styled trade relations" with the Andokes people, but at the same time they were explicitly "termed punitive expeditions," payback for the theft of rifles and the killing of civilized Colombians.⁷⁶ The resistance of the Andokes people was used as justification for slaving expeditions: the phrase "trade relations" was a euphemism for the attempt to "capture Indians and compel them to come in and work for Señor Sanchez."⁷⁷ The primary norm of civilized society, trade, was synonymous with the enslavement of the uncivilized.

⁷⁴Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 23.

⁷⁵Valcárcel, *El Proceso Del Putumayo y Sus Secretos Inauditos*, 21-22.

⁷⁶Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

⁷⁷Casement, *Correspondence*, 11.

Like the Andokes people, the Huitoto also attempted to steal rifles from their enslavers. Casement's report narrates the story of an unnamed 'capitán' of the Huitoto who was being held prisoner at the Matanzas station. After another native worker managed to multiple times escape capture, this capitán sent his son on an errand to bring him a rifle that he had secreted away in his house in the forest. The son was caught smuggling the rifle into the station and was hanged. The father was subsequently also hanged, but not before being beaten with machetes. One of the Barbadian workers, an Augustus Walcott, expressed some mild sympathy with the natives, remarking that "this was not the way to punish people" and that "it was a brutal act."⁷⁸ Walcott was threatened with punishment for making this comment, and for an evidently unrelated incident was himself later beaten with machetes and hanged - but by his hands rather than his neck, and so he survived.

This expression of sympathy between the Barbadians and the Putumayo natives was not isolated, but such expressions were overwhelmed by conflict between them. Of course the Barbadians were mostly employed in violently forcing the natives to work, and the fact that they seem to have been compelled to do so by the violence visited on their own heads does not negate the fact that they behaved brutally towards the native workers. They were therefore occasionally the targets of acts of resistance. Although rifles were not easy to come by for the native peoples, they had other methods of resisting enslavement and death. Some simply ran away and evaded capture, but they also enacted positive means of self defense, attacking and wounding the company's employees. Casement notes that the Andokes and Boras peoples were sometimes successful in killing their would-be capturers, and he says that one Barbadian man, Clifford Quintin, had been wounded in one of his feet when they met. "This wound has been caused by a

⁷⁸Casement, *Correspondence*, 14.

splinter of wood, probably poisoned, placed in the ground by the Indians in order to obstruct the approach of their dwelling places, in the hope of thereby hindering the armed raids made upon them to compel them to work rubber."⁷⁹ The employment of such means of defense around their homes was not merely retaliatory violence, but was quite literally a defense of their homes, and communities - their patterns of life.

But the patterns of life among the native communities were precisely the target of colonial violence - it was the 'savagery' that would be wiped out by civilization. Taussig notes that the practices and culture of the native Putumayans were interpreted very differently by the Peruvians and Casement. Casement emphasizes the irrationality of fearing the Putumayans, indicating that their communities were fractured and they were both too poorly armed and too docile to provide much resistance. But among Peruvian and Colombian settlers, the natives were seen as almost mythically dangerous. When the Colombian slavers were killed by the people they tried to enslave, Casement's informant says that the only reason they did not eat them was "that Indians 'had a repugnance to eating white men, whom they hated too much.'"⁸⁰ Even the lack of cannibalism in this instance was somehow twisted into evidence of savagery.

Thus resistance to colonial expansion was turned into fodder for the intensification of colonial activity. It was portrayed as uncivilized 'savagery' or 'malas acciones' and used to justify a far greater degree of brutality. This pattern, in which resistance to colonial violence is metabolized by the colonial beast and revisited on the indigenous population, is accompanied by a great mythmaking. Taussig notes two related themes around which these myths coalesce: "the horrors of the jungle, and the horrors of savagery."⁸¹ The Amazon jungle was a place of horrors

⁷⁹Casement, *Correspondence*, 13.

⁸⁰Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 489; and Casement, *Correspondence*, 30.

⁸¹Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 482.

which degrades those who enter, and the people who have made it their home are, naturally horrific themselves. In the context of Peru's project of civilizing the jungle, the native population took on a "powerfully ambiguous image, a seesawing, bifocalized, and hazy composite of the animal and the human. In their human or human-like form, the wild Indians could all the better reflect back to the colonists the vast and baroque projections of human wildness that the colonists needed to establish their reality as civilized (not to mention business-like) people."⁸² In their hybrid identity, the native peoples of the Amazon served a dual purpose for the rubber companies: they were both the engines of civilization as laborers, and the object of civilization as savages in want of pacification.

For the companies and state actors engaged in the project of civilizing the jungle, the acts of resistance by the indigenous Amazonians were crucial, in that they provided justification for the project itself. The fact of their pacification and employment as laborers meanwhile - which should be considered not a natural state *à la* Casement, but a state created and enforced by unimaginable violence - provided proof of the project's success. Both the resistance of the Putumayo peoples and the violent reprisal were elements in the project of genocide-as-accumulation. They figured into its creation as well as into its reproduction and maintenance.

It is important to note here that even the liberal humanism which opposed the genocide, such as expressed in Hardenburg's travelogue, was still fully committed to the construction of colonial hegemony. This comes through clearly in certain passages both of his book, and in the introduction to his book written by a friend and fellow engineer Charles R. Enock. Both authors object to the brutality of the PAC's actions against the indigenous Putumayans, but remain committed to a racial hierarchy that positions non white people as in need of the edifying power

⁸²Taussig, "Culture of Terror," 483-4.

of labor discipline. Enock in particular views peoples of the Putumayo as "worthy of preservation" in so far as they are docile and free from immorality. He projects an explicit framework of racial classification in which some peoples are more valued than others. He initially rejects the prevailing racialization of the indigenous Putumayans, saying that "[t]hese people, although known as *infieles* and *salvages* - that is, 'un-faithed' and 'savage' - cannot be described as savages in the ordinary sense of the term. They have nothing in common with the bloody savages of Africa and other parts of the world."⁸³

Even Enock's praise is built on the devaluation of other races, but faint as it is he cannot hold onto it for long. A mere two pages later he attempts to describe the various peoples in Peru, saying "[t]he highland and coast people were those who formed the population under the Inca government, and under whose control they had reached a high degree of aboriginal civilisation; whilst the indigenes of the forests were more or less roving bands of savages, dwelling on the river banks, without other forms of government than that of the *curacas*, or petty chiefs of families or tribe." As evidence of the virtue of the people in the coastal region, Enock says they live under an intelligible structure, in which "every village contains its *iglesia* and village priest."⁸⁴ In perhaps the most bizarre expression of his racial calculus, Enock develops an explanation of why the Peruvian 'Christians' would commit such terrible crimes, and why the English stockholders should to some extent be exudes. To quote somewhat at length:

"Apart from topographical considerations, the sinister occurrences on the Putumayo are, to some extent, the result of a sinister human element - the Spanish and Portuguese character. The remarkable trait of callousness to human suffering which

⁸³Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 16.

⁸⁴Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 19.

the Iberian people of Portugal and Spain - themselves a mixture of Moor, Goth, Semite, Vandal, and other peoples - introduced into the Latin American race is here shown in its intensity, and is augmented by a further Spanish quality. The Spaniard often regards the Indians as *animals*. Other European people may have abused the Indians of America, but none have that peculiar Spanish attitude towards them of frankly considering them as non-human.[...]There is yet a further trait of the Latin American which to the Anglo-Saxon mind is almost inexplicable. This is the pleasure in the torture of the Indian as a *diversion*, not merely as a vengeance or 'punishment.'"⁸⁵

The explanation? That the Peruvians carry bad Iberian blood, blood of a lower class. Enock's analysis exists within a rigid racial hierarchy - even his criticism of ethnic cleansing reinforces colonial hierarchy. This is a criticism not *of*, but *internal to* the Civilising Project.

Both the genocide itself and the critical viewpoint embodied by Hardenburg and Enock shared a common goal: the pacification of the indigenous population and their transformation into a docile class of workers, and the production of rubber for the world market. Although Enock and Hardenburg balked at the violence of the genocide, the worldview they shared is precisely that which created it. The genocide cannot be reduced either to an attempt at labor discipline nor to simple bloodlust, because they cannot be extricated. The brutality of the individual perpetrators of the genocide may have been motivated by a capricious love for violence, but it took place in and was conditioned by the context of accumulation. The extermination of the Putumayo peoples was instrumentalized by the forces of capital as a crucial element of the world-system.

⁸⁵Hardenburg, *The Devil's Paradise*, 37.

Conclusion

By the time Casement had arrived in Peru, both the population of the indigenous residents of the Putumayo and the rubber output of the region had fallen considerably: from about 50,000 inhabitants in 1906 to "not more than 8,000 in 1911," and from 645,000 kilograms of rubber to 236,000 in the same period. Despite this, Casement's notes that the individuals exploiting the Putumayo seemed unconcerned: "The disappearance of the London company as an active factor restricts the necessities of profit finding to a narrower field. While it needed a heavy output of hundreds of tons of rubber in 1906 upon which to found an appeal to British investors or speculators in 1907 ... a diminished yield of only 200 tons will still maintain many families and individuals on the spot."⁸⁶

According to the correspondence included in Casement's consular report, by July of 1911 the Peruvian government had issued more than 200 arrest warrants for the perpetrators of the Putumayo genocide. However, "[m]any [had] escaped to Brazil. Only accessories remain[ed] in the territory."⁸⁷ Many of the warrants were voided by Peruvian courts or tied up in bureaucratic technicalities in an attempt to bury the matter.⁸⁸ In 1913 the Peruvian Amazon Company was dissolved, but Arana maintained his estates and continued exploiting their rubber and residents.⁸⁹ Over 6,000 inhabitants of the Putumayo - evidently most of the remaining residents, if Casement's numbers were correct - were forced to leave their home territory in the late 1920s by two of Arana's managers. Half of them died on the march.⁹⁰ In the 1920s Arana became a

⁸⁶Casement, *Correspondence*, 157.

⁸⁷Casement, *Correspondence*, 147.

⁸⁸Pilar Jordán, "A Propósito de Redes Sociales, Económicas y Políticas En La Iquitos de Inicios Del Siglo XX," *Boletín Americanista*, ISSN 0520-4100, N°. 56, 2006, Pags. 103-118, January 2006, 112.

⁸⁹J. Goodman, *The Devil and Mr. Casement: One Man's Battle for Human Rights in South America's Heart of Darkness* (Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2010), 239.

⁹⁰J.V.S. Román et al., *Perfiles Históricos de La Amazonía Peruana* (Centro de Estudios Teológicos de la Amazonía, 1994), 192-3.

Peruvian senator. In 1927 the territorial conflict over the Putumayo was finally settled between Peru and Colombia in favor of Colombia. Arana resisted the treaty, but managed to ensure that he would be compensated for his property. A Colombian bank bought Arana's rights, but he died before receiving the full payment. In the 1980s, a Colombian bank paid his heirs \$160,000.⁹¹ Taussig approvingly cites Edmund Morel's claim that the intervention spearheaded by Casement was one of the "only two [occasions] in which British diplomacy rose above the commonplace" and helped bring an end to the genocide. I'm not so sure. The rubber genocide in the Putumayo did not end because of external pressure, but because Arana ran out of people to kill.

The genocide cannot be reduced to its economic dimension. Taussig refers to market pressure as a 'trigger' - not the only cause of the genocide, just its immediate context. But although the market may not have demanded the specific torture of the Huitoto people, it did demand a radical reconfiguration of life in the Putumayo. Meeting the market demand for rubber in previously unimagined quantities required a logic of extraction to be imposed on the land, and labor discipline to be imposed on the workers. New forms of social and capital reproduction developed in response to the rise of industry in the Global North - both its need for raw material inputs, and its need for an increased market for consumer goods. The structure of the global market made way for this reconfiguration to be borne out by especially bloodthirsty actors in the remote region of the Putumayo.

The atrocities discussed here are more violent and more shocking than the debt bondage of the lower Amazon and the racial stratification in Detroit Michigan, but they are part of the same system. In each location, capital operated within the prevailing political, social, and natural constraints to establish a compliant workforce that could cheaply produce automobiles or their

⁹¹Echeverri, "The Putumayo Indians and the Rubber Boom," 17.

constituent raw materials. The following chapter will look at another such location: South and Southeast Asia, where rubber was first grown productively on plantations. In sparsely populated Colonial Malaya, British owned and run plantations imported workers from Southern India. In doing so they created and maintained new forms of racial stratification and labor discipline, transforming the local patterns of social reproduction toward the production of profit.